

Checklist

Understanding Platforms

1. Understand What Makes a Platform

- ☐ Explain how a platform **elevates** participants by letting them build on existing capabilities rather than starting from scratch.
- ☐ Remember that platforms generate value through **interaction between participants**.
- ☐ Explain why a platform without participants provides little or no value.
- ☐ Distinguish a true platform from something that has merely been relabeled as one.
- ☐ Explain why platform strategy is about enabling participants to benefit from the presence of others.

2. Know the Main Benefits of Platforms

- ☐ **Enable:** make interactions or transactions easier.
- ☐ **Democratize:** lower barriers to participation.
- ☐ **Self-perpetuate:** create positive feedback loops as participation grows.
- ☐ **Accelerate:** remove common or repetitive work so users can focus on differentiation.
- ☐ **Avoid unnecessary constraints:** provide reusable capabilities without forcing every participant into the same solution.

3. Learn the Automotive Platform Lesson

- ☐ Explain how automotive platforms reuse expensive underlying engineering across multiple vehicle models.
- ☐ Understand how standardization can increase—not necessarily reduce—product diversity.
- ☐ Identify what should be **harmonized in the platform** versus what should remain **variable on top**.

- ☐ Remember the danger of “**badge engineering**”: near-identical products with superficial differences are not effective platform engineering.
- ☐ Explain why both the platform and the differentiated products built on top matter.

4. Understand Marketplace Platforms

- ☐ Define a marketplace as a platform that connects two or more customer groups to facilitate transactions.
- ☐ Distinguish the **farmer’s market model** from the **supermarket model**.
- ☐ Explain why a marketplace usually does not own the inventory being exchanged.
- ☐ Identify possible revenue sources: buyer fees, seller/listing fees, transaction fees, membership fees, advertising, or third parties.
- ☐ Explain the marketplace **flywheel**: more buyers attract more sellers, more sellers increase selection, and greater selection attracts more buyers.
- ☐ Recognize the **chicken-or-egg problem** of attracting both sides of a marketplace.

5. Understand Cloud and Base Platforms

- ☐ Explain how cloud platforms remove infrastructure “heavy lifting.”
- ☐ Recognize that developers consume reusable infrastructure and services rather than building everything themselves.
- ☐ Understand that platform value depends not only on **what is inside**, but also on **how easily users can access it**.
- ☐ Know the main interaction methods:
 - ☐ Web console
 - ☐ CLI
 - ☐ APIs
 - ☐ Infrastructure-as-Code / automation
- ☐ Explain why reducing user friction and cognitive load is important.
- ☐ Remember: **how users access the platform can be as important as its capabilities**.

6. Know the Four Technology Platform Types

- ☐ **Marketplace**
 - ☐ Purpose: facilitate transactions between participant groups.

- ☐ Typical interaction: browser, mobile app, APIs.
- ☐ **Base Platform**
 - ☐ Purpose: rapidly provision technical/IT resources.
 - ☐ Typical interaction: console, CLI, APIs, automation.
- ☐ **Developer Platform**
 - ☐ Purpose: increase development speed, reuse, and governance.
 - ☐ Typical interaction: portals, command line, APIs.
- ☐ **Business Capability Platform**
 - ☐ Purpose: expose business-domain capabilities and enable an ecosystem.
 - ☐ Typical interaction: APIs and custom integrations.

7. Understand Developer Platforms

- ☐ Explain why organizations create internal developer platforms.
- ☐ Know the main goals:
 - ☐ Reuse common IT services.
 - ☐ Improve developer productivity.
 - ☐ Support governance and operational guidelines.
 - ☐ Support the software development lifecycle.
- ☐ Recognize examples such as software delivery, runtime, and data analytics platforms.
- ☐ Understand the risk of building a restrictive **cloud wrapper** that reduces developer choice rather than increases productivity.
- ☐ Consider the need for internal marketing, consulting, and support for platform users.

8. Understand Business Capability Platforms

- ☐ Distinguish business capabilities from general technical/developer capabilities.
- ☐ Recognize that business capability platforms reflect the organization's specific domain.
- ☐ Explain why APIs are central to exposing business capabilities.
- ☐ Understand how an internal capability can be **externalized** to partners or ecosystem participants.
- ☐ Consider additional requirements such as:
 - ☐ Public APIs
 - ☐ Multi-tenancy
 - ☐ Scalability

- ☐ Data security
- ☐ Legal considerations
- ☐ Explain how exposing business capabilities can create new revenue streams and market opportunities.

9. Evaluate Whether Something Is Really a Platform

- ☐ Does it enable participants to gain value from one another or from reusable shared capabilities?
- ☐ Does it reduce friction for users?
- ☐ Does it provide meaningful choice rather than unnecessary restrictions?
- ☐ Are users able to access its capabilities easily?
- ☐ Does it encourage reuse while leaving room for differentiation?
- ☐ Is the organization actually engineering a platform rather than simply renaming an existing product or service?
- ☐ Is the balance between standardized platform capabilities and variable capabilities built on top appropriate?

10. Remember That Platform Types Can Be Combined

- ☐ Do not treat the four types as mutually exclusive.
- ☐ Recognize that marketplaces can run on base platforms.
- ☐ Recognize that developer platforms can run on cloud/base platforms.
- ☐ Recognize that internal platforms can later be externalized.
- ☐ Recognize that business capability platforms can help customers build their own marketplaces.
- ☐ Understand the **layered/fractal nature** of platform ecosystems.

Final Review

- ☐ I can define a platform in my own words.
- ☐ I can explain why participant interaction matters.
- ☐ I can describe the major benefits of platforms.
- ☐ I can explain the marketplace flywheel.
- ☐ I can distinguish marketplace, base, developer, and business capability platforms.
- ☐ I can give an example of each platform type.

- ☐ I can explain why access and user experience matter as much as platform functionality.
- ☐ I can explain the dangers of over-standardization and restrictive platforms.
- ☐ I can identify what belongs **inside the platform** versus what should remain **variable on top**.
- ☐ I can evaluate whether a proposed “platform” actually exhibits platform characteristics.